OVERVIEW

The Engagement Blueprint

The Blueprint organizes seven connected design decisions across three lesson phases. Establish the learning intention first, protect the conditions for student thinking during the lesson, and consolidate the learning after students have had something substantive to examine and discuss.

BEFORE · 1A

Establish the Learning Intention BEFORE the Lesson

Plan the content and concept first. Every decision in 1B through 2D ties back to the learning intention.

- **1A** Select the content and concept

DURING · 1B – 2C

Student Thinking DURING the Lesson

Protect the conditions for student thinking. Use artifacts, a high-cognitive prompt, intentional grouping, visible thinking, and extended discussion as one connected experience.

- **1B** Analyze multiple artifacts, look for patterns
- **1C** Use a high-cognitive prompt
- **2A** Intentionally group students
- **2B** Provide open space to make thinking visible
- **2C** Protect extended small-group discussion time

AFTER · 2D

Consolidate Student Thinking AFTER Substantial Thinking Time

Consolidate learning after students have had substantial time to think. This may happen midway through the lesson, at the end, or both.

- **2D** Reify learning as a class; students make notes

1A Select the content and concept

DEFINITION

Content is factual knowledge: information, vocabulary, facts, and skills. Concept is the big idea or relationship that helps students organize the content. *For one lesson, it may be a lesson-sized gist rather than the unit's broadest concept.*

EXAMPLE

Digestive system: content = organs and functions. Gist = food enters, is broken down, useful material is absorbed, and waste exits. (Unit concept = homeostasis)

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Select both before teaching.
- Help students encounter the gist through familiar experiences or everyday language.
- Connect the gist to formal details and terminology.
- Make decisions about 1B through 2D that tie back to the learning intention.

LESS LIKE

- Starting with content, such as definitions, details, and factual information.
- Treating a topic as a concept.
- Forcing every lesson to use the unit's largest concept.

WHEN IT HAPPENS During planning, aligned to the milestone and unit. Surface the gist before or as students begin encountering the details.

STUDENT THINKING DURING THE LESSON

1B Analyze multiple artifacts, look for patterns

DEFINITION

Artifacts are anything students can examine and annotate. Students compare them to find patterns, relationships, differences, contradictions, categories, or questions.

SELECTING ARTIFACTS INTENTIONALLY

VARIETY AND QUANTITY

A manageable set of rich artifacts: enough to compare, few enough to go deep. Text, images, video, case studies, graphs, data tables, maps, etc. One text can count as multiple artifacts when students examine it through different lenses, such as each group following a different character.

LOCATION

Close and tangible. A laminated or sleeved group set works; students can photograph notes.

TIMING AND EFFICIENCY

Give artifacts all at once or drip them in. Be mindful of time and relevance.

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Decide whether groups receive the same, different, or overlapping sets.
- Give each student or group a physical copy of every artifact to mark up.
- Annotate beyond marking: write the thinking behind each underline, circle, or question mark, summarize sections, and record take-home messages.

LESS LIKE

- Adding artifacts for quantity, or one modality by default.
- A gallery walk that prevents side-by-side comparison.
- Answering worksheet questions instead of recording thinking on or alongside the artifact.
- Artifacts in a textbook, slide, or smart board that students cannot mark up.

WHEN IT HAPPENS During the central thinking period, alongside 1C and 2A–2C. The artifact is the first place students write. Annotations then feed the group's shared thinking in 2B.

STUDENT THINKING DURING THE LESSON

1C Use a high-cognitive prompt

DEFINITION

A high-cognitive prompt asks students to analyze, explain, justify, interpret, synthesize, compare, connect, or find patterns and relationships. It can be a question or a statement.

EXAMPLE

Instead of only “What do you notice?” try “What patterns do you notice across the number representations?”

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Open enough that students choose an approach and construct an answer.
- Focused enough to direct attention toward the relationship or feature that matters.
- Pair the prompt directly with the artifacts.

LESS LIKE

- Recall, one-answer, or leading questions.
- Vague prompts when direction matters.
- Assuming any open-ended question is high cognitive, or prescribing the analysis in ten steps.

WHEN IT HAPPENS Designed with 1B before class, posed during the central thinking period, and revisited during reification.

2A Intentionally group students

DEFINITION

Group students so they can process ideas together, then use a participation structure that allows everyone in the group to contribute. Intentional may mean visibly random, teacher-selected, or student-selected when each serves a clear purpose. Groups are flexible and temporary.

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Use visibly random triads as a strong default in grades 3–12 and pairs in K–2.
- Group for mixed perspectives, temporary support, interest, artifacts, access, or contrasting strategies.
- Keep groups flexible, temporary, and at four or fewer.
- Use a participation structure so every member contributes to the thinking.

LESS LIKE

- Fixed ability groups or the same students repeatedly.
- Large groups that permit hiding or self-selection that reproduces exclusion.
- Narrow roles that divide the thinking, or seating students together without a shared intellectual need.
- Placing students in a group with no structure for everyone to contribute.

WHEN IT HAPPENS Decide the purpose during planning, form groups as the task begins, and adjust when the composition blocks access, participation, or productive thinking.

STUDENT THINKING DURING THE LESSON

2B Provide open space to make thinking visible

DEFINITION

Provide a shared workspace large enough for the group and task. “Blank” means students construct the organization, not that the surface must contain nothing. It may be paper, a whiteboard, a digital canvas, or a field of sticky notes.

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Include the high-cognitive prompt and, when needed, essential terms, constraints, or a few success criteria.
- Let students choose how to show relationships through diagrams, equations, models, annotations, or explanations.
- Expect different groups' work to look different.

LESS LIKE

- Fill-in-the-blank work or prescribed question sequences.
- An organizer that determines all relationships, or defaulting to CER.
- Final answers without visible reasoning; front-loaded scaffolds that do the thinking for students.

WHEN IT HAPPENS Throughout the central discussion. The visible record creates accountability and helps the teacher monitor, probe, identify misconceptions, and select ideas for 2D. Add scaffolds responsively.

STUDENT THINKING DURING THE LESSON

2C Protect extended small-group discussion time

DEFINITION

Protect enough uninterrupted time for students to orient to the task, inspect evidence, exchange interpretations, revise ideas, and create a shared representation. Fifteen to twenty minutes is a strong planning benchmark, not a rule.

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Match time to students, artifacts, and cognitive demand.
- Use fewer, richer artifacts when needed.
- Circulate to listen, probe, connect groups, and address consequential misconceptions.

LESS LIKE

- Treating a three-minute turn-and-talk as deep discussion.
- Spending twenty minutes silently dividing work, decorating, building slides, or manipulating technology.
- Rushing through artifacts, or telling students what to do.

WHEN IT HAPPENS During the central portion, often one-third to one-half of the period, alongside 1B, 1C, 2A, and 2B. Some tasks may extend across lessons.

CONSOLIDATE STUDENT THINKING AFTER SUBSTANTIAL THINKING TIME

2D Reify learning as a class; students make notes

DEFINITION

Reification turns provisional group ideas into shared, accurate, and usable understanding. Students build on one another's thinking; the teacher records, orchestrates, and ensures disciplinary accuracy. Students make or revise notes from the synthesis.

DESIGN COMPARISON

MORE LIKE

- Select and sequence contributions that are useful, contrasting, or reveal misconceptions.
- Ask students to compare what they heard and explain how their thinking changes.
- Connect direct teaching to student ideas; consolidate task-specific and transferable learning.

LESS LIKE

- Every group presenting in sequence or the teacher repeating each response.
- Treating presentations as reification or revealing an unrelated answer.
- Copying predetermined notes or resolving every question during exploration.

WHEN IT HAPPENS After students have examined, discussed, and represented ideas. Exploration may preserve uncertainty; later work may formalize content, vocabulary, and repair misconceptions.